Neal T. Gillespie

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Hiring Committee
Round Rock Public Library
City of Round Rock
Round Rock, TX 78664

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am applying for the Library Assistant position in Youth Services at the Round Rock Public Library. I live in Austin, so this is a library I could serve without relocating. Every job I have held has been inside an educational institution or a nonprofit built to serve students: a university law school, an organization that runs educational programs and conferences for college students, and a university where part of my work was the campus library. Students have been the constant of my career, and a library is where I have been deliberately working to end up.

I should be straightforward about the one thing I cannot claim. My experience is with students aged eighteen and up, not with children and teens. What I can offer is more than four years of continuous public-facing service to students in settings whose whole purpose was helping somebody learn something, and genuine eagerness to take this role as the way to build far more experience in the library field than I can get from coursework alone. The age-group work I would learn from the people who already do it.

My title is Direct Mail Production Manager at Young Americans for Liberty, a nonprofit that runs donor-funded educational programs and conferences for college students. I manage the archive of every printed piece we produce, which means taking samples in from the printer, sorting and labeling them, shelving them by campaign and mail code, keeping the shelves accurate, and pulling what somebody needs. When I inherited that collection I designed a SQL database for it, set a consistent record for each piece, cataloged several campaign years against that standard, and built a searchable reading room over the top, so the whole department can find a past piece on its own.

I built two public websites the same way: the Free Knowledge Library, a digital library of political literature drawn from across the ideological spectrum, where I designed the site, the database and the classification scheme and built the catalog readers search; and StateTrack, which publishes state campaign finance records for all fifty states. When a patron cannot find something in a catalog, I understand why from the inside.

The closest I have come to this role is at the University of Austin, where part of my work was the campus library. I worked with a donor on a gift of a complete *Harvard Classics* set, carried it from the first conversation through to the books being on the shelf, gave them a tour of the library in person, and kept them updated on where the set had been placed. I was also the on-site contact for visitor tours, guiding groups of all ages and answering their questions about the collections. That is what convinced me to pursue this work properly.

Earlier, as a student registrar at Chapman University’s Fowler School of Law, I staffed the service window as the first person students talked to, explaining procedures that were not obvious and processing more than five hundred transcripts and exam records accurately. I have also produced displays and printed material to publicize programs, and coordinated check-in and on-site logistics for conferences serving up to a thousand students.

I have begun the ALA’s Library Support Staff Certification and begin a Library and Information Services certificate at Central Community College in the spring, with a master’s in library and information science to follow. I noticed Round Rock offers tuition assistance, which is a genuine part of the appeal. Thank you for your time, and I would welcome the chance to talk.

Sincerely,

Neal T. Gillespie